

What has enraged the Church most is the attempt by the LDF Government to control the lucrative higher education sector dominated by the Catholic churches which runs a large number of schools and colleges in the state. The first move by the Government was to regulate admission and fees in private self-financing professional colleges. A government-appointed commission fixed fees at Rs 35,000 and up to Rs 2.5 lakh per semester, respectively, for engineering and medical courses even as the managements insisted on almost double the amounts. Though the Government's moves have been stalled by the managements with the help of courts, the student wings of CPI(M) and CPI have been physically trying to stall functioning in many colleges in protest against higher fees. They even stormed into some minority colleges when two students, allegedly harassed by the managements, committed suicide.

The Church has also opposed the Government's decision to hand over the control of all government-aided and government schools to the respective panchayats as part of decentralisation of powers. "The communists are trying to politicise education as most panchayats are run by them," said a church leader. The Government's plan to introduce centralised "single window" admission system for class XI in government-run and aided schools has also enraged the Church. This system will take away the managements' monopoly over admissions. The Church even suspects that the Government is planning many anti-religious measures like banning pictures of gods in schools, scrapping holidays on Sundays and compelling Catholic nursing students to attend classes on abortion, a taboo for the Church. The Government, however, debunks such fears. "All this was utter nonsense. It was done by some rabid anti-communist elements in the Church to incite fears in the commu-

HOLY ALLIANCE: Advani being greeted by bishops at Kottayam



M.A. BABY, EDUCATION MINISTER

If Jesus was alive he would have left this Church and become our Politburo member.

Some anti-communist elements in the Church are trying to incite fears in the community.



V.S. ACHUTHANANDAN, CHIEF MINISTER

nity," says Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan. In fact, the Government has shelved its decision to introduce sex education in schools.

However, what the Church and managements fear most is the Government's fiercest weapon: proposal to hand over the appointment of teachers in government-aided private schools and colleges to state Public Service Commission. This would mean the end of a major source of revenue for them as the managements give appointment letter to the highest bidder—prevailing rate is Rs 10 lakh for a schoolteacher's job—even though the salaries are paid by the Government in

aided schools. "This has to be ended forthwith. Managements which have the authority to appoint should be made to pay the salaries too," says former chief secretary C.P. Nair, who headed the government-appointed Commission for Educational Reforms. Many lower caste Hindu and Christian organisations which resent upper caste dominance on education have welcomed the suggestion.

Though not as vocal as the Catholics, other Christian churches have also pledged support in this movement against the Government. Upper caste Hindu groups like the Nair Service Society, which runs many educational institutions, have lent support to the Church.

Not that the Church's virulent anti-communism stand has not seen some resentment from within. Joseph Pulikkunnel, a prominent religious scholar, has blasted the Church's "meddling" in the personal lives and preferences of the laity. "Anti-communism is a lucrative business which will bring in lots of cash from the West," he says. Raju Abraham, a Marxist MLA who is Christian by religion, called the Church's moves "fascist". Abraham says the Church's fears have grown now because, unlike in the past, Christians no longer loathe the communists as shown by the Left's unprecedented electoral gains in many Christian-dominated areas.

The CPI(M) leaders have pooh-poohed the Church's plans to launch another liberation struggle to oust the Government and lashed out at it for its pro-BJP stance. "In his anti-communist outburst Powathil has forgotten the series of atrocities committed against Christians and some other atrocities in most BJP-ruled states," says CPI(M)'s mouthpiece *Deshabhimani*. "It was the Congress government at the Centre which had dismissed our government in 1959 to appease the Church. But today the Congress at the Centre is dependent on us for its survival," says Achuthanandan. ■